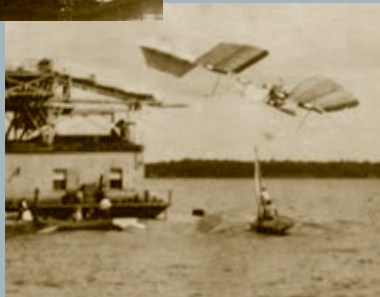


LAUNCHING THE GREAT AERODROME



DASHED DREAMS

The first attempt to fly the Great Aerodrome was made in October 1903. Catapulted on a trolley along a track atop a houseboat, the flying machine headed downward the moment it reached the end of the track and plunged into the Potomac. The "pilot" was rescued and the wreck of the Aerodrome towed away for repair.



ON OCTOBER 7, 1903, engineer Charles Manly climbed aboard a massive flying machine perched on top of a houseboat on a stretch of the Potomac River 40 miles (65km) south of Washington, D.C. The machine was Samuel Pierpont Langley's Great Aerodrome, the product of a costly four-year project to achieve manned heavier-than-air flight. An audience of journalists and military and scientific observers had been invited to witness its first takeoff.

Manly was a mechanical wizard who had devised the

airplane's innovative 52hp lightweight gasoline engine. He was expected to function as more of a passenger than a pilot, since Langley's machine was supposed to be so stable it would fly itself.

With the engine running sweetly, Manly raised his arm and a laborer wielded an ax, cutting a retaining cable. The catapult trolley shot forward, accelerating the Aerodrome to the end of its launch track. Langley described the fiasco that followed: "Just as the machine left the track, those who were watching... noticed that the machine was jerked violently down at the front... and under the full power of its engine was pulled into the water, carrying with it its engineer." Manly struggled clear of the plane to be rescued.

Langley was now under enormous pressure to deliver on his promise of manned flight. By the time the Aerodrome had been repaired it was winter. On the afternoon of December 8, conditions were far from favorable but, as

